offensive base, ‘this country will do whatever must be done to protect its own security and that of its allies’.[79] Inasmuch as Kennedy and his advisers (his DCI excepted) did not believe Khrushchev would send nuclear missiles to Cuba, these warnings were directed more at domestic opinion than at Moscow.

The CIA and the United States intelligence community believed Khrushchev would not take the gamble. This was made clear in a Special National Intelligence Estimate (SNIE) presented to the President by the inter-agency United States Intelligence Board on 19 September. When the missiles were discovered, Sherman Kent, the CIA analyst who chaired the Board of National Estimates that drafted the SNIE, told his staff that if he had to go back and do it all again, he would reach the same conclusion.[80] In 1964 he wrote of the ‘incredible wrongness of the Soviet decision to put the missiles into Cuba.’[81]

When JFK issued his public warnings in September, almost none of his senior advisers believed the Soviets would put ‘offensive’ weapons in Cuba. The lines were drawn in the sand on the assumption that the tide was not coming in. Yet at that very moment, the MRBMs were already arriving. Khrushchev was hardly likely to turn them around at this stage. Would he have pursued his gamble if Kennedy had issued the warnings earlier in the year? Everything would presumably have depended on how Khrushchev assessed Kennedy’s determination to follow through on his rhetoric.

The Soviet Premier did react to the President’s September warnings. On 25 September he decided to cancel most of the naval deployment, including the seven Project 629 submarines, with their twenty-one nuclear-armed missiles. The surface fleet was also cancelled, except for the Komar patrol boats (with their short-range conventional missiles). However, it was decided that the four Project 641 submarines (B-4, B-36, B-59 and the B-130) would now be equipped with nuclear-armed torpedoes. These weapons were armed with fifteen kiloton warheads, greater than the yield of the bomb dropped on Hiroshima.

One person who took a different view of Khrushchev’s risk-taking was the Director of Central Intelligence, John McCone. While CIA analysts were convinced that Khrushchev would not deploy nuclear missiles in